about Assamese identity and Hindu identity. In Tripura, it is about Hindu identity.'[31] The party has built a multi-layered identity in the Northeast, emphasising different things in different states.

To make sense of this, it is vital to understand the make-up of the region. Colonial Assam—loosely analogous to what was known in ancient India as Pragjyotisha-Kamarupa—encompassed India's Northeast, barring the princely states of Manipur and Tripura and the kingdom of Sikkim.[32] The primary fault-line in old Assam, which came under British control in 1826 after the Treaty of Yandaboo,[33] was between people in the 'plains' and the tribes in the 'hills'. This was formalised by the Bengal Eastern Frontier Regulation of 1873, which instated an 'inner line' along the foothills as a way of demarcating these areas. The British saw the hill people as different as from those in the plains, and governed them—much as they governed the North West Frontier Province (now in Pakistan)—by essentially leaving them alone.[34] The difference was that, in the Northeast, the British allowed a host of foreign Christian missionaries: the Baptists and the Welsh Presbyterians in Meghalaya's Cherrapunji in the 1830s,[35] followed by the American Baptist Mission in Sibsagar from 1836.[36] Their presence had a profound impact on tribal communities even as, after Indian independence, the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution guaranteed autonomy to tribal communities in several north-eastern states through Autonomous District Councils.[37]

Simultaneously, India's independence opened up years of political ferment in the Northeast, leading to the country's longest-running separatist insurgencies—starting with Naga leaders who proclaimed a 'Naga National Council' in 1946 and a Naga Federal Government in 1955; the Mizo National Front uprising in 1966 that led to the Indian Air Force aerially strafing insurgent targets in Aizawl the same year (the only time IAF has been used in offensive operations on Indian soil);[38] as well as insurgencies in Manipur, Tripura and Assam.[39] It was this instability that led to the enactment of the Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act, 1958[40] that remained in force in some parts of the region in 2021. The Northeast has been India's 'Troubled Periphery' for decades—to quote the title of a fine